3 – Scaffolding

MLI Rubrics Project – Lesson 3.mp4

Objective

By the end of this unit, you will be able to:

- Reverse-engineer your own prompt.
- Identify required components of a correct and complete response.
- Structure those components into a clear, logical scaffolding that mirrors the ideal reasoning process.

What is Scaffolding?

Now that you've created your prompt, it's time to begin outlining the steps you would take to solve it. Imagine you're completing the task yourself. **Map out the steps you would take to arrive at a perfect answer.** This is what we call **scaffolding:** a bullet-pointed outline of the steps needed to arrive at the ideal answer.

To create this scaffolded outline, **you need to ask yourself what steps, tasks, and calculations you** – or any other component person in your profession – **would have to perform** to answer the prompt and complete the task. So you functionally are reverse-engineering your own thought-process as an expert in your profession to answer the prompt.

This isn't the fully developed answer yet – that will come when you develop the rubric. Instead, it's the **blueprint outline** for the answer.

The Purpose of Scaffolding

Scaffolding your response will help you to brainstorm the steps and tasks that need to be completed to successfully respond to the prompt. It creates the clear, logical flow of reasoning anyone would need to successfully complete your prompt. And it will also help the reviewers of your work to see the birds-eye-view of the steps needed to respond to your prompt before they dive into the all the criteria you develop in your most fleshed-out rubric.

The rubric you eventually create will ultimately need to have all of the components that an ideal answer to the prompt that you have made would require – but scaffolding will help you to have the outline for what your rubric will need to cover.

How to Create a Scaffolded Outline

- Imagine completing the task yourself
- Ask: What steps, tasks, and calculations would an expert need to perform?
- Outline those steps in a logical sequence
- Keep the outline focused and high-level – not fully fleshed-out yet
- **Important**: Please add criteria ranges to each item on your scaffolding. This will help you as the writer start to think about the rubric, as well as linking the scaffolding to the rubric

Scaffolding Example

So for example, we had a prompt that one of our experts made in investment banking that asked you to prepare for a strategic meeting with JetBlue's board, after the proposed acquisition of Spirit Airlines was blocked. The prompt asked us to:

- Propose some target airlines and put together overview pages on them. In this instance, you will focus on Sun Country, Southwest, and Frontier.
- Include relevant information for each company that is necessary to determine which airlines would be feasible for a potential acquisition.
- If you want to see the full prompt –check your project guidelines of the types of prompts that we're looking for on this project

Here is what the scaffolding looked like for this prompt:

Scaffolding example:
• Criterion 1-3: Identify key personnel (CEO, CFO, Board Chair) for Southwest, Sun Country, and Frontier. • Criterion 4-8: Accurately state stock price and market capitalization for each target airline as of 5/16/2025. • Criterion 9-12: Identify the headquarters city for each target airline. • Criterion 13-15: List primary/hub airports (1-5) for each target airline as of Q1 2025 earnings. • Criterion 16-18: Include FY2024 performance metrics (RASM, CASM, load factor, average stage length, average cost of fuel/gallon) for Frontier and Southwest. • Criterion 19-21: Include FY2024 performance metrics (RASM, CASM, load factor, average stage length, average cost of fuel/gallon) for Sun Country. • Criterion 22-24: Identify Southwest's total aircraft fleet and aircraft type breakdown as of Q1 2025. • Criterion 25-28: Identify Sun Country's total aircraft fleet and aircraft type

breakdown as of Q1 2025.
- Criterion 29-30: Identify Frontier's total aircraft fleet and note the lack of breakdown by aircraft type as of Q1 2025.

As you can see, scaffolding is not the fully developed answer – it's the blueprint for the answer that allows you and your reviewer to understand your overarching thought process.

Moreover, it does not contain the actual answers to the prompt. Instead, it provides an outline for the model on how to approach the prompt's answer step-by-step

Summary

To conclude, here are some good general guidelines to follow when it comes to scaffolding:

- Use a clear bullet-point or numbered list.
- Focus on logic, sequence, and coverage.
- You can group related steps.
- Be concise. Avoid complete sentences unless needed.